

soon extended to outright dubious ones. Perhaps Harshad started to have delusions about his power – that companies' performance would improve because *he* had invested in them!

The post-Budget excitement in the market lifted the Sensex to 1,900 by mid-September. In less than two and a half months of the Congress government's coming to power, the index had rallied an astounding 50 per cent.

July and August had been bumper months for me. I netted Rs 41,000 in jobbing commissions in July and Rs 46,000 in August. And yet, I was disappointed for not having been able to hit the Rs 50,000 mark. Each month I took Rs 25,000 out of these profits home, depositing the rest with my employer, with the intention of taking bigger bets when the opportunity arose.

Bauji and Ma were awestruck when I handed them my earnings. Bauji had some idea about the stock market and its fickle ways, but he found it hard to believe that a 23-year-old could make Rs 25,000 two months in a row.

'I hope you are not doing something wrong, Lalchand,' he told me one evening after dinner.

'No Bauji, every rupee has been earned the hard way. And this is just the beginning. With my efforts and God's grace, we should be able to move to Ghatkopar in two years' time,' I said. I could understand his concern; my wayward ways during our days in Bhandup were still fresh in his memory. I could see that he was not entirely convinced by my answer, and that he did not want to voice his doubts either.

'Bauji, I know I have caused you grief in the past, but that's a closed chapter. I give you my word that I will never do anything that will cause you to hang your head in shame,' I said, clasping his hand. That put him at ease somewhat.

'But tell me, Lala, if you can make Rs 25,000 two months in a row, you could also lose that much, isn't it?' he asked.

'True, that's why I pre-decide the quantum of loss I can bear and stay within that limit. If I exceed that, I am likely to get fired from my job,' I said.

Unlike me, moving into a bigger house was not Bauji's priority. Satish had enrolled for a B.Sc. that year as his Higher Secondary score was not high enough to get him a seat in a good engineering college purely on merit.